however, was before her marriage to Gogoi in 2013. Sarma also points to Elizabeth's nine visits to Pakistan, and her refusal to clarify the status of a Pakistani bank account. He claims she shared sensitive information with Pakistani authorities, citing a 45-page document she allegedly sent in August 2014 that apparently referred to Intelligence Bureau reports and strategies to "bypass the central government".

Gogoi rejects Sarma's presentation as "mindless" and "C-grade cinema" theatrics, calling it retaliation for the Congress's claim that Sarma's family had allegedly occupied 12,000 bighas of land. He acknowledges visiting Pakistan in 2013 but says it was a personal trip. "We were newly married. We went to see where she stayed, which bazaar she went to, where she ate," he says. He defended his wife's work as part of legitimate international programmes, and argued that if national security were genuinely at risk, Sarma would not have waited six months after the SIT report to act—squarely placing the impending polls as a motive.

Takeaways

- **Himanta Sarma accuses Gaurav Gogoi, wife of having 'Pak links', cites 2013 trip**
- **Gogoi calls it "C-grade cinema" meant to divert focus from graft allegations**

The allegations are grave in themselves but, besides the unexplained timing, they also need to stand up to scrutiny. Despite charges bordering on treason, there's no formal case. If Gogoi genuinely posed a national security threat, it's unclear why a BJP government at the Centre took no action for a decade. The SIT, too, never questioned Gogoi. Gogoi's answers, on their part, also seem to lack granular detail. But then, no one has accused anyone here of being obsessed over the fine print. ■

RAJASTHAN

Distress Over Bill

A bill to guard against distress sales during communal tumult—itself causes tumult

By **Rohit Parihar**



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

STRETCHED SPACE Jaipur's Muslims are concentrated in areas such as the Walled City

THE QUESTION IS LESS ABOUT the propriety of the law seen in isolation, but whether Rajasthan needed it at all. What is it about? A 'Disturbed Areas' bill the state government has introduced in the ongoing budget session of the assembly, opening fresh political and ideological fault lines. The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) pitches it as a safeguard against distress property sales during communal disturbances. The Congress warns that the bill itself marks a deliberate attempt to communalise the state, since it's historically not known to be prone to religious polarisation.

No immediate catalyst was in sight when, on January 21, the Bhajan Lal Sharma cabinet cleared the draft of the Rajasthan Prohibition of Transfer of Immovable Property and Provision for Protection of Tenants from Eviction from Premises in Disturbed Areas Bill, 2026. The bill, tabled in the House on January 28, would empower the state to notify specific localities as "disturbed areas", making prior official permission mandatory for the transfer of immovable property in those zones. The objective, say cabinet ministers, is to prevent forced migration and distress sales in riot-hit localities.

The bill comes close on the